

Crossing the globe

Barn swallows are found across much of the world, and each year most cross the equator in their migrations—between North and South America or the wildest stretches of Asia. Swallows from Europe even travel across Africa's Sahara Desert to reach their wintering grounds.

North America

Barn swallows in North America breed from May to August. The swallows here—like those in far eastern Siberia—have reddish-brown, rather than pure white, underparts.

Caribbean passage

Swallows migrating south from North America either island-hop through the Caribbean, or follow the path of land through Central America.

South America

Barn swallows arriving in South America reach Colombia and the Guianas by late August, and Brazil, Paraguay, and Argentina by September.

Europe

Throughout summer, barn swallows breed across Europe, and as far south as northern Africa. Most of those from northern and central Europe start their migration south in September or October.

Africa

Barn swallows overwinter across vast regions of Africa: birds arriving from western Europe tend to head to the west, and those from eastern Europe to the east. The longest distance traveled between Europe and Africa is an incredible 7,245 miles (11,660 km).

Barn swallow

More than half of all bird species are small perching birds, or passerines. Many are expert at hunting insects on the wing. Barn swallows nest and raise their young in the northern summers, when the skies are buzzing with life. But they must migrate to the warmer tropics before winter comes and insect numbers fall.

